



AN INVESTMENT COMMITTEE BRIEFING

The Indie Economy, Decoded

What 1,000 real startups reveal about building, buying, and backing bootstrapped & micro-SaaS businesses in 2026.

Data source: TrustMRR — 1,000-company dataset (frozen 30 Jul 2026) ·
Prepared for: Founders, Operators, Investment Committee · Strategy &
Data Insights · Aug 2026



01 — Executive Summary

The headline numbers — and the single story that explains almost all of them. This briefing surfaces the distributional structure, cross-market signals, and what investors should prioritize when evaluating micro-SaaS and bootstrapped startups.

Executive summary — Nine numbers that matter

The headline numbers below show the shape of the market: scale, concentration, revenue quality, and exit opportunity.

1,000 companies Tracked across 65 countries and 29 categories.	\$13.47M MRR Combined recurring revenue across the dataset.	\$282 median MRR Half of companies earn less than this each month.
19.7% at \$0 MRR Nearly one in five companies has no recurring revenue.	48% from top 10 Almost half of all MRR comes from ten companies.	26.5% from Stan One company contributes more than a quarter of total MRR.
0.88 correlation Paid subscribers and revenue move almost in lockstep.	2.3x revenue multiple Median marketplace sale price versus revenue.	26% listed for sale More than a quarter of companies are on the market.

Source: TrustMRR 1,000-company dataset · Frozen 30 Jul 2026. Figures are directional where coverage is limited — see data caveats.

One chart tells the whole story

Stan — outlier

Generates \$3.57M MRR — larger than the bottom 900+ companies combined.

Top 1% concentration

Top 10 companies account for ~48% of total MRR; hits-driven returns.

Median reality

Median MRR = \$282/month; the typical outcome is modest relative to the ceiling.

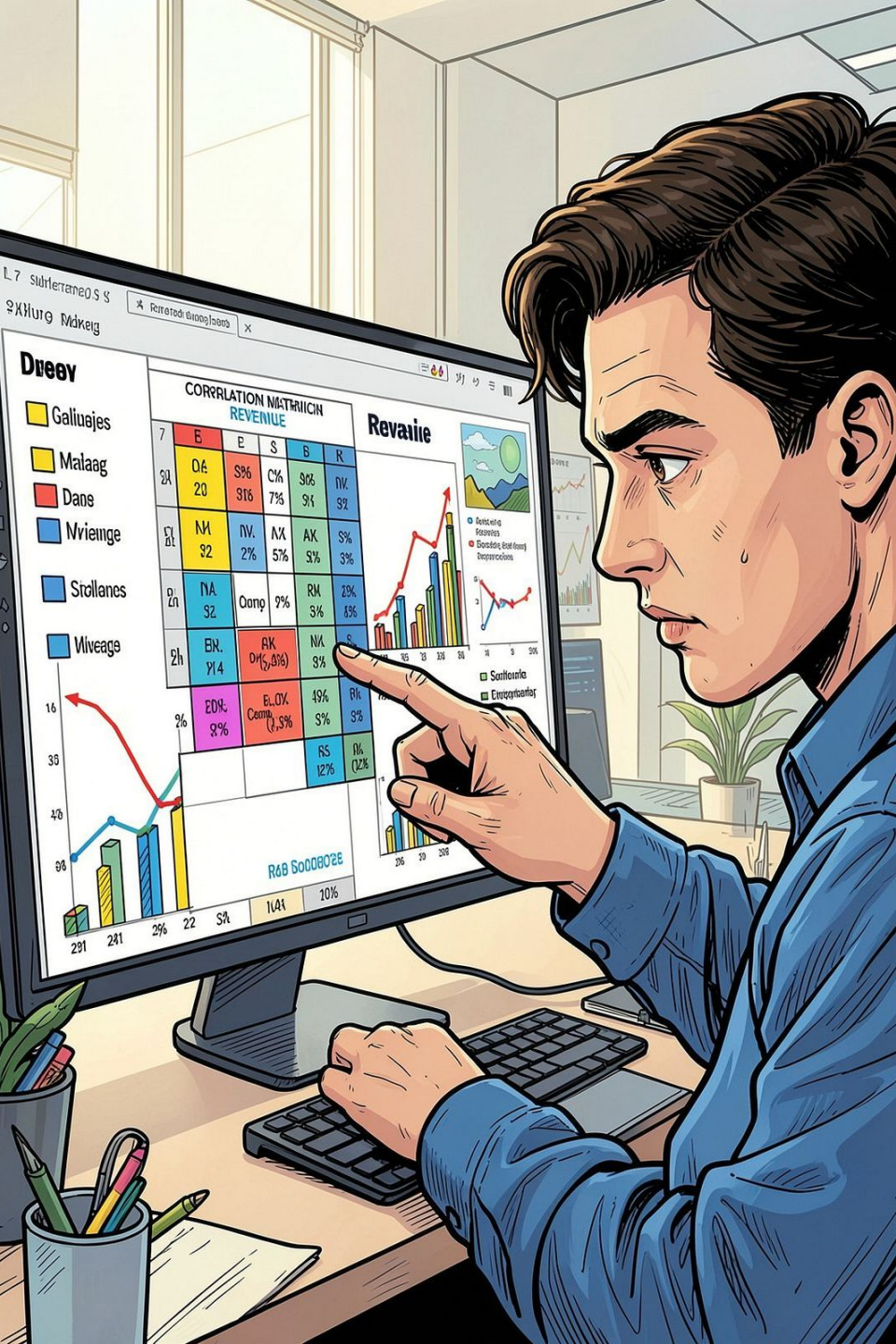
02 — Understanding the companies

Who is in the dataset and where the data goes dark. Most entries are founder-led, early stage, and uneven in disclosure. Treat granular segment-level metrics as directional where noted.



Opportunities & Risks

- Exit market: **2.3x revenue multiple**
- B2B under-monetized: **5x value per account**
- Search/content authority: **DR 16.7/100**
- Top 10 concentration: **48%**; Stan: **26.5%**
- Marketplace/Games: **40%+ zero-revenue**
- AI overcrowding: **5x founders**, weak monetization



03 — Key Drivers of Revenue

What actually predicts success in the indie economy? Data points to clear signals, with some surprising insights into what truly moves the needle for bootstrapped and micro-SaaS ventures.

Paid Subscribers

0.88 correlation — the strongest signal in the dataset. Growth in active, paying users is a direct and reliable indicator of monetization quality.

Domain Rating / SEO

0.48 correlation — a real, compounding advantage for organic discovery. With an average domain rating of just 16.7/100, this is a **wide-open opportunity** for most companies.

X/Twitter Followers

0.18 correlation — a weak signal. While social presence can be valuable for community, it is not a direct predictor of recurring revenue within this market segment.

- ❑ Focus on building a strong subscriber base and investing in organic search for sustainable, high-quality revenue growth.

07 — Hidden Patterns & Surprising Insights

Three findings that challenge conventional wisdom in the bootstrapped and micro-SaaS landscape, revealing deeper market dynamics.

1

Audience Size is a Vanity Metric

There's a negligible **0.02 correlation** between social media followers and Monthly Recurring Revenue (MRR). Growth in audience numbers rarely translates directly to financial success.

2

The Best Companies Are Often For Sale

Companies actively on the market have a median MRR of **\$1,055**, which is **5.6x higher** than the **\$187** median for unlisted companies. They are typically priced at **2.3x revenue**.

3

Popularity Doesn't Mean Monetization

The **AI category** has the most companies (197), yet its median MRR of **\$446** lags significantly behind sectors like **Education (\$2,142)**, **Marketing (\$1,586)**, and **Analytics (\$1,294)**.

05 — Customer & Business Characteristics

Understanding the typical customer and operational setup reveals key strategic implications for both growth and investment.

B2B Leads in Value

B2B customers deliver **5x higher median MRR** (\$49/mo) compared to B2C (\$9/mo). Despite fewer companies, B2B contributes **\$3.35M** total MRR, significantly outpacing B2C's **\$2.04M**.

Freemium is Standard

Of companies disclosing pricing (65.7%), over half (**52.7%**) offer a free tier. This highlights the widespread adoption of freemium as a primary acquisition and monetization strategy.

Stripe's Stronghold

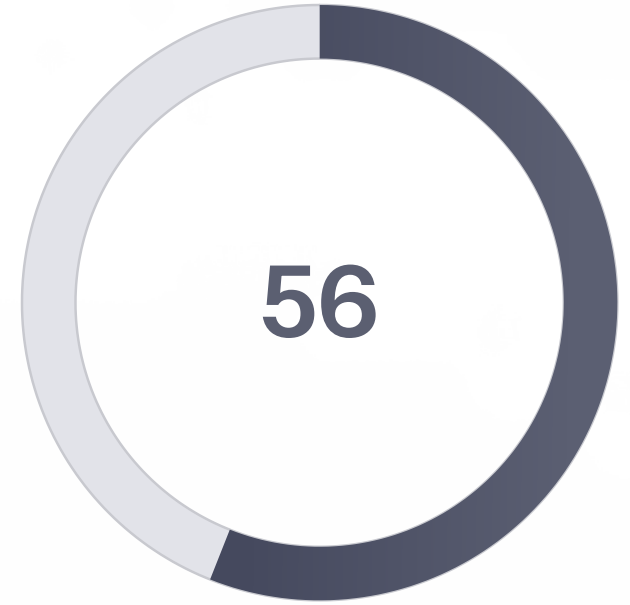
Stripe is the dominant payment processor, utilized by **636 companies** in the dataset. RevenueCat follows with 189, underscoring Stripe's ecosystem prevalence in bootstrapped SaaS.



B2C



B2B



Both



Data coverage & important caveats

1

Stealth / anonymized

129 companies labeled “Stealth Company” — key fields intentionally blank.

2

Field coverage gaps

Country: 76% known ·
Category: 73% known ·
Value prop: 70% known ·
Domain rating: 71% known.

3

Sparse performance signals

Visitors available for only ~14–18% of records.

4

Market listings

Asking price present for ~26% — primarily active listings.



Interpret all category and geography insights as directional. Use caution when deriving prescriptive unit economics from incomplete records.

03 — Market Landscape

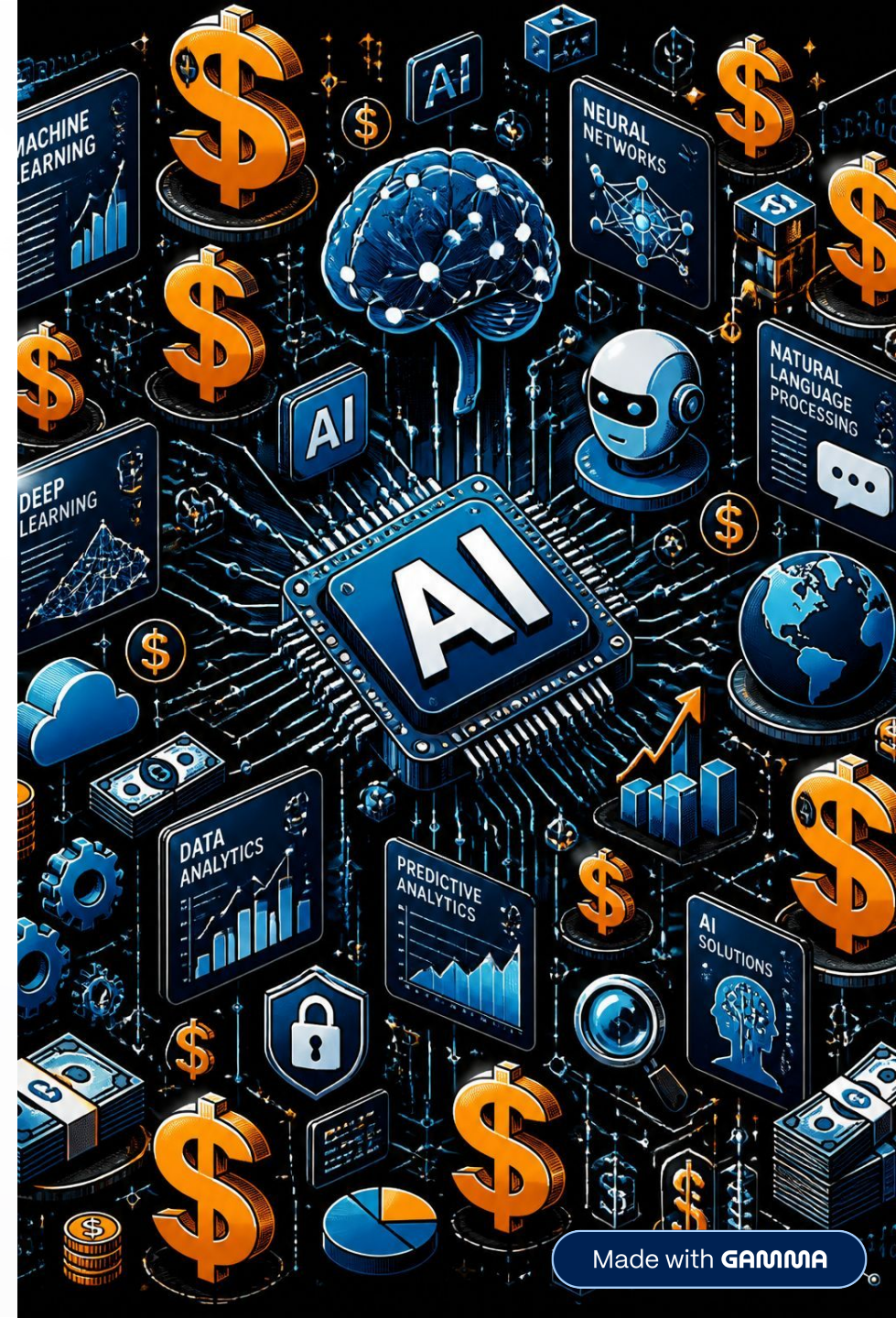
Where companies cluster, and where high-quality revenue concentrates. Geography correlates with monetization quality as much as volume.



AI category: headcount vs revenue quality

AI is the largest category by count ($\approx 20\%$ of companies) but underperforms on median revenue. Headcount and category share do not yet translate to superior MRR — many AI startups remain pre-monetization or in freemium experimentation.

- ☐ **Category share**
1 in 5 companies classify as AI or AI-adjacent.
- ☐ **Revenue signal**
Median AI company earns less than 50% of median Education or Analytics company MRR.
- ☐ **Investor caution**
AI requires selective underwriting — product-market fit and monetization path matter more than buzz.



10 – Final Takeaways: Five Things to Remember

1

Power-Law Distribution

The top 10 companies command 48% of total revenue, with a single entity (Stan) accounting for 26.5%, highlighting extreme market concentration.

2

B2B's Untapped Potential

B2B customers deliver 5x higher revenue per account, yet the segment remains less saturated compared to B2C, offering significant growth opportunities.

3

Paid Subscribers Drive Revenue

A strong **0.88 correlation** exists between paid subscribers and MRR, while social media followers show a negligible **0.18 correlation**.

4

Disciplined Exit Market

Companies actively listed for sale exhibit **5.6x higher median MRR** and maintain consistent **2.3x revenue multiples**, indicating a robust and rational exit landscape.

5

Popularity ≠ Monetization

Despite being the most crowded category, AI companies monetize significantly less than less popular sectors like Education or Analytics.

09 — Strategic Recommendations: If You're Building

Five data-backed moves to optimize your bootstrapped or micro-SaaS venture for success and maximize monetization potential.



Prioritize B2B Value

B2B customers offer **5x higher median MRR** per account. Direct your efforts towards business clients for substantially greater financial returns.



Freemium as Baseline

With **52.7%** of companies already offering a free tier, freemium is a market expectation, not a differentiator. Focus on conversion strategies from free to paid.



Invest in Search & Content

Domain Rating has a **0.48 correlation** with revenue. Start building organic search authority early; the average DR of **16.7/100** indicates a significant untapped opportunity.



Don't Overvalue Social Reach

Social media following has a negligible **0.02 correlation** with MRR. While community is valuable, raw audience size rarely translates directly to financial success.



Scrutinize Category Monetization

Some categories, like Marketplace/Games, show **40%+ zero-revenue** companies. Contrast this with Analytics/Sales, which have much stronger monetization profiles. Choose wisely.